



“In FY25, Tata Steel achieved its highest crude steel production ever at 21.7 million tonnes (MT) and deliveries of 20.9 MT, driven by near full capacity utilisation across sites”

T.V. NARENDRA
CEO & MD, Tata Steel

tion, India crop protection, seeds and specialty chemistries. “It was a shift away from a unified approach to enable more targeted growth within each business,” he says.

Other initiatives were portfolio optimisation, digital integration, capital efficiency and ESG integration.

TIGHTENING THE SCREWS

One of the major turnaround stories has been scripted by the Anil Ambani-promoted Reliance Group India, earlier known as the Reliance ADA Group. Two of its companies, Reliance Infrastructure and Reliance Power, became debt-free. Net worth took off and financial standing improved. A group spokesperson says “Reliance Power has emerged as India’s largest integrated player in solar plus battery energy storage system with a clean energy pipeline for solar at 3.2 GWp and a storage capacity exceeding 3.3 GWh.” Reliance Infrastructure, it added, through its partnership with Dassault Aviation, “will manufacture Falcon 2000 business jets outside France for the first time.” The boards of the companies have approved plans to raise ₹18,000 crore through a combination of equity and debt.

Vipin Singhal, Director of Anand Rathi Investment Banking, says the group’s pivot to high-growth sectors such as defence (Reliance Infra) and renewable energy (Reliance Power) has helped. “Plus, its partnerships with global firms like Diehl Defence and

major solar-plus-storage projects have helped reshape market perception from distressed assets to turnaround stories,” he says.

But one worry is the recent Enforcement Directorate summons in a suspected ₹17,000 crore loan fraud case involving the group. Besides, State Bank of India and Bank of India have classified the loan account of Reliance Communications as fraudulent and named Anil Ambani, over alleged fund diversion in 2016, according to an exchange filing. Singhal thinks it will impact the companies. “The stocks hit the lower circuit, reflecting heightened investor concern and uncertainty. If the operational progress is maintained with financial discipline, they may rebound only after the case stabilises,” says Singhal.

There were a few who took a slightly different path. In the instance of Essar Shipping, CFO & Whole-time Director Vipin Jain says they remain committed to optimising value across the global portfolio. He credits strategic financial management for the rise in FY25 profit after tax. “This growth was driven by monetisation of select investments, closure of outstanding loans and foreign exchange loans,” he says.

For companies that are back in the black, the sense of optimism is palpable. UPL’s Prasad, for instance, expects to maintain a higher growth trajectory versus the projected global crop protection market CAGR (compounded annual growth rate) of approximately 2% over the next five years.

“This will be supported by volume gains, innovation and strategic execution. We continue to maintain our FY26 guidance of 4-8% revenue growth and 10-14% EBITDA growth,” he says. For Tata Steel’s Narendran, the confidence comes from the ability to maintain a resilient balance sheet.

LOOKING AHEAD

Obviously, nothing tightens a company more than a challenging phase. Glen Saldhana,